Sankofa Community Development Corporation: Community-Led Green Spaces And Food Access Education In New Orleans

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This interview was conducted with Rashida Ferdinand, Founder & Executive Director of Sankofa Community Development Corporation.

Founded on the belief that communities create the best solutions for themselves, Sankofa Community Development Corporation (CDC) was started in 2008 by Rashida Ferdinand with the support of community stakeholders. The CDC created an integrated approach that addresses environmental health, food access, and economic development as one interconnected ecosystem.

Sankofa CDC's mission is clear: build healthier communities for generations to come. They've achieved this goal through their holistic model of environmental leadership, food justice, and economic justice. Starting with the Sankofa Wetland Park and Nature Trail, a 40-acre wetland park that houses various species of birds that have returned to the area since its development, and a living wetland laboratory where environmental scientists and engineers study. To fight against food injustice, they established the Sankofa Fresh Start Market in 2024, a community-centered green grocery that also houses a teaching kitchen and café with family-centered cooking classes, all in an effort to foster healthy food habits. Lastly, supporting local wealth by developing community-owned businesses like the Sankofa Gardens, a 20,000 square foot urban farming space built on formerly vacant lots. All this has helped Sankofa CDC serve over 800 local family households monthly and plant thousands of edible plants, pollinators, Louisiana bald cypress trees, and a variety of flora in the Lower 9th Ward.

Q: Katrina displaced so many families and disrupted entire communities. How does Sankofa CDC's work help repair or strengthen what was lost?

Rashida Ferdinand: Our organization has remained committed to redevelopment and rebuilding in a way that centers people's needs and voices. That also means not accepting the conditions we experience as normal. There are people here who remember when there were more homes, when streets flooded less, when fresh food was more accessible, and when health disparities weren't as prevalent.

So we're working to make our space a model for what healthy, thriving communities should look like. There are still major barriers we don't control, including financial systems, housing, insurance, and infrastructure. But, we believe our role is direct community investment and partnering with others to advocate for the larger policy and systemic changes that impact people's ability to truly live and thrive in New Orleans.

Q: Twenty years after Katrina, what does your organization's existence say about New Orleans' resilience and the community's ability to rebuild on its own terms?

RF: Twenty years later, our existence shows that New Orleans is resilient, but it also shows that we still have a lot of work to do. It's important that we have more empowerment around how finances are allocated to our communities, what gets invested, and how those investments are utilized. We need a real plan that includes equitable, resourceful support for people who do not have the same means as those in more affluent areas. We also need real attention to what it means to support people's voices, respect the culture of this city, and address affordable housing. And give attention directly to our infrastructure systems and how they impact the land and water systems in which we live.

Q: What does success look like in your work, and what's the closest you've come to that in the past year?

RF: Success is having a team with synergy that is working with joy, because that extends to all of the people we connect with. For us, that means having the technical experience, passion, care about the work, and a clear understanding of it. The ideas have to be put into action and applied, and success is having a mission-aligned network of people; our core staff, our partners, our allies—who are connected to this work.

When I think about what has made me feel successful and grounded this past year, it's the people who are part of this work. Seeing our team get really excited when they see other groups doing serious community advocacy work, people who care about humanity, that feels like success. The success is when we are trying to make a footprint that supports a more beautiful, just, and healthy world.

Q: When you think about the next 20 years, what role do you see Sankofa CDC playing in the continued recovery and reimaging of New Orleans?

RF: When I think about the next 20 years, I see some of the capital projects we've developed having a central role as a model that supports a healthy and resilient ecosystem in New Orleans. In the Lower 9th Ward, where we focus our development work, we restored a 40-acre wetland park that is a green space supporting habitats for over 80 different bird species, along with a significant variety of animals, flora, and fauna. That space also tells the story of our history, our culture, and the people who have lived here and experienced this environment. I think what we're doing in this neighborhood shows the importance of green spaces, a healthy environment, fresh food, and a healthy agricultural economy, while also providing us information on what it means to be self-reliant and self-resilient, especially in a disaster-prone area.

Q: If your organization achieves everything it's set out to do, how will New Orleans be different for the people you serve?

RF: The air will be cleaner, the water will be healthy, and people will have a home that's affordable—it's a given, not a challenge. Healthy food would be a right, fully accessible to everyone. That's one of the reasons why we started the Fresh Start Market. It shouldn't cost us to have our health or access to healthy food. Our children would be educated about the importance of a healthy environment in a way that is collective and hands-on.

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Your support makes this work possible. A gift of any size helps Sankofa Community Development Corporation continue serving the community and building a stronger, more resilient city for everyone.

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